Frequentist, Bayesian and Machine Learning Analysis of the Matter–Antimatter Asymmetry in $B^{\pm} \to K^{\pm}K^{+}K^{-}$ Decays at LHCb

Final project for the *Statistics and Data Analysis* course
Academic Year 2025–2026

Giacomo Moretti and Marco Belotti
Università degli Studi di Milano-Bicocca

[TODO: Giacomo + Marco, write last. 3–5 sentences: dataset (LHCb Open Data, $B^{\pm} \to K^{\pm}K^{+}K^{-}$), the three methodological approaches compared (frequentist MLE/profile likelihood, Bayesian MCMC, ML-assisted selection), the headline result (A_{raw} estimate + consistency across methods), one sentence on what's new/interesting (e.g. goodness-of-fit model comparison, local Dalitz asymmetries). Don't give every number here – see §IX guidance.]

I. INTRODUCTION

Charge-parity (CP) violation – the small observed asymmetry between the behavior of matter and antimatter – is one of the necessary ingredients for the matter-dominated universe we observe, yet the CP violation built into the Standard Model is far too small to account for it. Studying CP violation in the decays of B mesons, where it is comparatively large and experimentally accessible, is one of the main ways to test the Standard Model's CKM description of the effect and search for physics beyond it. Charmless three-body decays such as $B^{\pm} \to h^{\pm}h^{+}h^{-}$ ($h = K, \pi$) are especially interesting in this respect: unlike a two-body decay, the three-body phase space (the Dalitz plot) allows the asymmetry to be studied not only as a single global number, but also *locally*, since interference between intermediate resonances can concentrate CP-violating effects in specific kinematic regions rather than spreading them uniformly [1, 2].

The quantity measured in this work is the raw asymmetry between the signal yields of the two charges,

$$A_{\text{raw}} = \frac{N(B^{-}) - N(B^{+})}{N(B^{-}) + N(B^{+})}. \tag{1}$$

It differs from the physical asymmetry A_{CP} by the production asymmetry A_P of $B^{\pm}$ mesons in pp collisions and by the detection asymmetry A_D of the final state; to first order in these small quantities,

$$A_{CP} \approx A_{\text{raw}} - A_P - A_D, \tag{2}$$

where A_D arises mainly from the different interaction cross sections of K^{+} and K^{-} with the detector material and depends on the kaon momenta [1]. Neither correction is applied here, so A_{raw} is not a measurement of A_{CP}.

In this work we use the LHCb Open Data record for $B^{\pm} \to K^{\pm}K^{+}K^{-}$ [3, 4] to address the question: *to what extent do frequentist likelihood fits, Bayesian inference, and machine-learning-assisted event selection produce consistent, well-controlled estimates of the raw asymmetry A_{raw} in this decay?* The aim is not a competitive measurement of A_{CP}, but a methodological comparison of the three inference frameworks on the same data and the same physical question. Section II describes the dataset and the preselection common to the three analyses; Secs. III and IV present the frequentist and Bayesian fits, Sec. V their common systematic study, and Sec. VI the machine-learning analysis; Sec. VII brings the three together.

II. DATA

A. Dataset and Preselection

The dataset is the CERN Open Data record 4900, "Matter Antimatter Differences – B meson decays to three hadrons" [3]: candidates for $B^{\pm} \to h^{\pm}h^{+}h^{-}$ decays collected by LHCb in 2011 at $\sqrt{s} = 7\,\text{TeV}$, reconstructed with the LHCb software and already passed through trigger and offline selection. The data are distributed as ROOT `TTree`s (`DecayTree`) containing only the most relevant reconstructed branches, split across two files by magnet polarity (magnet up/down), for a combined 8,556,118 candidates. The same record also includes a simplified, detector-response-free phase-space simulation of $B^{\pm} \to K^{\pm}K^{+}K^{-}$ (50,000 decays, half of each charge); it is used only as a sample without asymmetry to test the local-asymmetry procedure (Sec. IV H).

For each of the three final-state tracks ($H1$, $H2$, $H3$) the analysis reads momentum components (`PX`, `PY`, `PZ`), particle-identification (PID) likelihoods (`ProbK`, `ProbPi`), a muon flag (`isMuon`), and the track charge. The same preselection is used in all three analyses: a kaon-PID requirement and a muon veto on every track,

$$\texttt{H*_ProbPi} < 0.5 \ \wedge \ \texttt{H*_ProbK} > 0.5 \ \wedge \ \neg\texttt{H*_isMuon},$$

which retains 23,895 of the 8,556,118 candidates (0.28%), the PID requirement being by far the dominant reduction. The files contain no event identifier; as a proxy for multiple candidates from the same collision, only 42 of the candidates in the fit window (0.2%) share an identical track with another candidate, a negligible effect on the statistical uncertainties, and all are kept.

In this dataset only the charge combinations $(+1,-1,-1)$ and $(-1,+1,+1)$ occur for $(H1, H2, H3)$: $H1$ is always the kaon of charge opposite to the B, and $H2$, $H3$ are the interchangeable same-sign pair. The Dalitz-plot variables are therefore the invariant masses of the two opposite-sign pairs, $m^2(H1, H2)$ and $m^2(H1, H3)$.

B. Invariant Mass Reconstruction

The three final-state tracks are assigned the charged-kaon mass hypothesis ($M_K = 493.677$ MeV) regardless of their PID likelihoods, and their four-momenta are summed to reconstruct the B candidate, $m(KKK) = \sqrt{(\sum_i E_i)^2 - |\sum_i \vec{p}_i|^2}$. The nominal fit window, common to the frequentist and Bayesian analyses, is $[5100, 5600]$ MeV. Below $\sim$5150 MeV the background rises, consistent with a partially reconstructed contribution that a single exponential cannot describe; the window includes the start of this rise, which is described by a second exponential in the background model (Secs. III–IV). This leaves 19,731 preselected candidates in the fit window: 10,292 with B-charge $+1$ and 9439 with B-charge -1, split 11,636 (magnet down) / 8095 (magnet up). The machine-learning analysis uses the same window, with the region below 5150 MeV excluded from its background-like training sample (Sec. VI A).

C. Data Exploration

Figure I shows the reconstructed mass spectrum in the fit window, split by B charge (left) and by magnet polarity (right). The spectrum peaks at $m \approx 5284$ MeV over a falling combinatorial background, with a similar shape for the two charges and the two magnet polarities. The charge-counting asymmetry of all candidates in the fit window, signal and background together, is $A_{\text{count}} = (N^- - N^+)/(N^- + N^+) = -0.043$.

III. FREQUENTIST ANALYSIS

[TODO: Marco – section intro: one or two sentences on the frequentist approach (unbinned ML fit with `iminuit`, profile likelihood). Subsections below still use "planned" wording; rewrite in the past tense with the results.]

A. Mass Model and Fit Strategy

The frequentist fit reuses the same physical mass model as the Bayesian analysis (Sec. IV A), $f(m) = N_s\, S(m;\theta_s) + N_b\, B(m;\theta_b)$, estimated by unbinned maximum likelihood (`iminuit` [5], an interface to MINUIT [6], with `iminuit.cost.UnbinnedNLL`) rather than by Markov chain Monte Carlo (MCMC) sampling. The plan is to start from the same minimal shapes as the Bayesian baseline (Gaussian signal, exponential background) and increase model complexity only if the residuals justify it – mirroring the Bayesian goodness-of-fit study (Sec. IV E), where a single exponential background is rejected by the data and a Crystal Ball signal improves the fit without moving A_{raw}. **[TODO: Marco – fill in once the mass fit is run: final signal/background shapes chosen, fitted yields N_s, N_b, and any residual-based justification for departing from the minimal model.]**

B. Separate vs. Simultaneous Fit

Two parametrizations are planned: a *separate* fit of B^+ and B^- independently, giving N_s^+ and N_s^- from which A_{raw} is computed post hoc, and a *simultaneous* fit using the shared parametrization $N_s^+ = N_s(1 - A)/2$, $N_s^- = N_s(1 + A)/2$ (the same parametrization already used on the Bayesian side, Sec. IV A) that estimates A directly as a fit parameter. Mass, resolution, and background-shape parameters are treated as nuisance parameters, profiled out when reporting the uncertainty on A. **[TODO: Marco – report A_{raw} from both parametrizations (should agree if the model is well-specified) and flag any disagreement as a modeling issue rather than a physics result.]**

C. Profile Likelihood and Confidence Interval

The profile likelihood ratio,

$$q(A) = -2 \log \frac{L(A, \hat{\hat{\theta}})}{L(\hat{A}, \hat{\theta})},$$

is used to derive a confidence interval on A via Wilks' theorem [7], and to test the null hypothesis $A = 0$ – the frequentist counterpart of the Bayesian Savage-Dickey test of Sec. IV D. **[TODO: Marco – report the MLE $\hat{A}$, the 68%/95% profile-likelihood confidence intervals, and the p-value/significance against $A = 0$; compare directly against the Bayesian credible interval of Sec. IV C ($A_{\text{raw}} = -0.0443$, 68% CI $[-0.0528, -0.0358]$) once available.]**

D. Systematic Uncertainties

The systematic study is common to the frequentist and Bayesian fits and is presented in Sec. V. **[TODO: Marco – anything specific to the frequentist fit (e.g. the window-edge grid scan of the notebook) as a stability check.]**

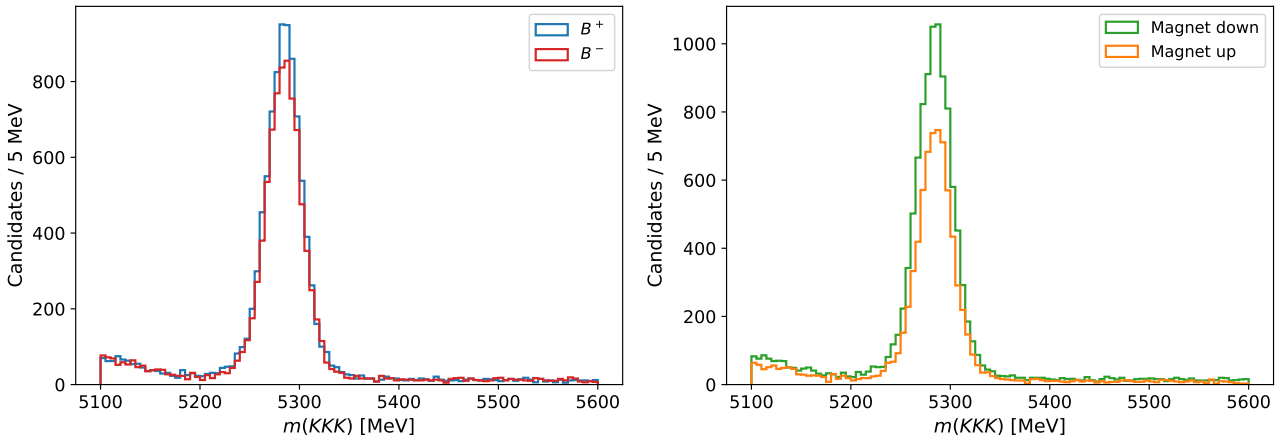


FIG. I. Reconstructed $B \to KKK$ invariant mass in the nominal fit window $[5100, 5600]$ MeV, split by B charge (left) and by magnet polarity (right). Both splits show a consistent peak at $m \approx 5284$ MeV over a falling combinatorial background, which rises below ∼5150 MeV.

IV. BAYESIAN ANALYSIS

A. Model and Priors

The mass spectrum of each charge sample is described by a signal-plus-background mixture on the nominal fit window $[5100, 5600]$ MeV (Sec. II B),

$$f^{\pm}(m) = N_s^{\pm}\, S(m;\mu,\sigma) + N_b^{\pm}\, B^{\pm}(m), \tag{3}$$

where S is a Gaussian truncated to the window, with mean μ and width σ shared by the two charges, and the background is a double exponential with a shape of its own for each charge,

$$B^{\pm}(m) = f_{\pm}\, E(m;\lambda_1^{\pm}) + (1-f_{\pm})\, E(m;\lambda_2^{\pm}),$$

with $E(m;\lambda) \propto e^{-\lambda m}$ a truncated exponential normalized on the window. The steep component (λ_1) describes the rise of the background towards the lower edge of the window, the slow one (λ_2) the combinatorial background under and above the peak. The mixture is invariant under the exchange $(\lambda_1, f) \leftrightarrow (\lambda_2, 1-f)$, which would give the posterior two identical modes (label switching); the ordering $\lambda_1 > \lambda_2$ removes this symmetry. Signal and background yields are split between the charges as

$$N_s^{\pm} = \tfrac{N_s}{2}(1 \mp A), \qquad N_b^{\pm} = \tfrac{N_b}{2}(1 \mp A_b),$$

so that $A = (N_s^- - N_s^+)/(N_s^- + N_s^+)$, the raw asymmetry A_{raw} of Eq. (1), is a fit parameter rather than being derived from two independent yields, and the background asymmetry A_b is free. The parameter vector has twelve components, $\theta = (N_s, N_b, A, A_b, \mu, \sigma, \lambda_1^{\pm}, \lambda_2^{\pm}, f_{\pm})$.

Given the data $D = \{(m_i, q_i)\}_{i=1}^{N}$ (mass and charge of each candidate), Bayes' theorem gives the posterior

$$p(\theta \mid D) = \frac{\mathcal{L}(D \mid \theta)\, \pi(\theta)}{p(D)}, \tag{4}$$

with the extended unbinned likelihood of the two charge samples

$$\mathcal{L}(D \mid \theta) \propto e^{-(N_s+N_b)} \prod_{i:\, q_i=+1} \Big[N_s^+ S(m_i) + N_b^+ B^+(m_i)\Big] \times \prod_{i:\, q_i=-1} \Big[N_s^- S(m_i) + N_b^- B^-(m_i)\Big], \tag{5}$$

where $S(m_i) \equiv S(m_i;\mu,\sigma)$. The priors are independent and uniform: $N_s, N_b \in (0, 5N)$ with $N = 19{,}731$, $A, A_b \in (-1, 1)$, $\mu \in (5260, 5310)$ MeV, $\sigma \in (3, 40)$ MeV, $\lambda_1^{\pm} \in (10^{-5}, 0.1)$ MeV^{-1}, $\lambda_2^{\pm} \in (10^{-5}, \lambda_1^{\pm})$, $f_{\pm} \in (0, 1)$. The prior density is therefore a constant on the allowed region Θ,

$$\pi(\theta) \propto \mathbf{1}\,[\theta \in \Theta]\,, \tag{6}$$

and inside it the posterior is proportional to the likelihood. A flat prior is not uninformative in an absolute sense, since it is not invariant under reparametrization (a prior uniform in λ is not uniform in $1/\lambda$); with $\sim 2 \times 10^4$ events, however, the posterior is dominated by the likelihood, as the prior-sensitivity check of Sec. IV F confirms for A. The evidence $p(D)$ is a constant normalization: the MCMC samples $\mathcal{L}\,\pi$ without computing it, and the Savage-Dickey ratio of Sec. IV D avoids computing it as well. The marginal posterior of the asymmetry, $p(A \mid D) = \int p(\theta \mid D)\, d\theta_{\neq A}$, is the histogram of the A component of the chain.

B. MCMC Sampling and Convergence Diagnostics

The posterior was sampled with the affine-invariant ensemble sampler of Goodman and Weare [8] as implemented in `emcee` [9]. The maximum of the posterior was first located numerically (Nelder-Mead), and 32 walkers were initialized in a narrow ball around it and

run for 25,000 steps, with the first 4166 (1/6) discarded as burn-in, leaving 6.7×10^5 samples; the mean acceptance fraction is 0.38. Convergence was checked through the integrated autocorrelation time of each parameter, $\tau = 1 + 2\sum_{t\geq 1} \rho(t)$, with $\rho(t)$ the autocorrelation of the chain at lag t. We find $\tau \in [147, 183]$ steps, the longest for the background-shape parameters: the post-burn-in chain is $N/\tau \geq 114$ autocorrelation times long for every parameter, above the threshold of 50 recommended for a reliable estimate of τ [9], and corresponds to $\gtrsim 3600$ effectively independent samples per parameter. To check that the chain is not trapped near its starting point, the fit was repeated twice with the walkers initialized uniformly over the whole prior box and the first half of the chain discarded: both runs converge to the same single mode, with $A_{\rm raw} = -0.0446$ and -0.0442, the same intervals and the same values of all other parameters as the nominal fit. The trace plot of such a run (Fig. XVIII, Appendix A) shows all walkers reaching the bulk of the posterior within ∼2000 steps, the background fraction f_+ last, well inside the discarded half of the chain.

C. Posterior Results and Credible Intervals

The marginal posterior on the raw asymmetry gives (median and equal-tailed credible intervals, CI)

$$\begin{aligned} A_{\rm raw} &= -0.0443, \\ 68\%\ \text{CI}\ &[-0.0528, -0.0358], \\ 95\%\ \text{CI}\ &[-0.0608, -0.0276]. \end{aligned}$$

The posterior is very close to Gaussian, with standard deviation 0.0085; its 68% interval is symmetric about the median to within 2×10^{-5}, so the equal-tailed intervals coincide with the highest-posterior-density ones at the quoted precision. Since the priors are uniform, the posterior mode (the maximum a posteriori, MAP, estimate, −0.0441) coincides with the maximum-likelihood estimate, so this result can be compared directly with the frequentist fit of the same model (Sec. III). The result has the same sign and order of magnitude as the published $A_{CP}(KKK) = -0.037 \pm 0.002\,(\text{stat}) \pm 0.002\,(\text{syst}) \pm 0.003\,(J/\psi K)$ [1, 2], which is the most that can be expected without the corrections of Eq. (2). The other physics parameters are $N_s = 15{,}328 \pm 133$, $N_b = 4404 \pm 82$, $A_b = -0.040 \pm 0.018$, $\mu = 5284.39 \pm 0.16$ MeV and $\sigma = 18.00 \pm 0.14$ MeV (Fig. II). A is almost uncorrelated with the other parameters: its largest correlation, −0.17, is with A_b.

D. Bayes Factors

Computing the evidence of each hypothesis by direct numerical integration is impractical for a 12-parameter posterior. When the null hypothesis fixes one parameter, H_0: $A = 0$, nested in H_1 (A free), and the priors on the other parameters are shared, the Bayes factor reduces to the Savage-Dickey density ratio [10],

$$BF_{01} = \frac{p(A = 0 \mid D)}{\pi(A = 0)}, \qquad \pi(A = 0) = \tfrac{1}{2}.$$

With equal prior probabilities for the two hypotheses, BF_{01} is also the posterior odds of H_0 against H_1. $A = 0$ lies 5.2 posterior standard deviations from the median, in a tail where the chain contains essentially no samples, so a kernel density estimate of $p(A = 0 \mid D)$ would only reflect the kernel tails of the few most extreme samples. We therefore use the Gaussian approximation of the marginal posterior (Sec. IV C), with the mean and standard deviation of the chain, which gives $BF_{01} \approx 1.1 \times 10^{-4}$ ($\ln BF_{10} \approx 9.1$): decisive evidence against $A = 0$ on Jeffreys' scale [11] ($BF_{10} > 100$). As for any Bayes factor of a point null against a free parameter, the value scales with the prior width – the Ockham factor built into the Bayes factor, which penalizes a free parameter in proportion to the prior volume it is allowed to explore, and the mechanism behind Lindley's paradox: with the narrower prior $A \in (-0.3, 0.3)$ of Sec. IV F, $\pi(A = 0)$ grows to 1/0.6 and BF_{01} drops by a factor 3.3, which leaves the conclusion unchanged. Figure III shows the two densities of the ratio.

The same test on the background asymmetry shows the Ockham factor at work. $A_b = -0.040 \pm 0.018$ lies 2.3 standard deviations from zero, yet the Savage-Dickey ratio gives $BF_{01}(A_b = 0) \approx 3.5$: the data mildly *favor* a charge-symmetric background, because the gain in likelihood does not compensate for spreading the prior of A_b over $(-1, 1)$. A_b is nevertheless kept free in the nominal model, which avoids imposing an assumption on the background that the frequentist analysis does not make; fixing $A_b = 0$ is one of the variants of the systematic study (Sec. V).

E. Goodness of Fit and Model Choice

A binned comparison of data and posterior-median model ($\chi^2 = \sum(\text{obs} - \text{exp})^2/\text{exp}$ over 50 bins of 10 MeV per charge, $100 - 12 = 88$ degrees of freedom) gives $\chi^2 = 164.1/88$ ($p = 1.6 \times 10^{-6}$), with 95.4 for B^+ and 68.7 for B^-. The largest pulls, in the B^+ sample, sit on the two flanks of the peak, about $\pm 3\sigma$ from μ (Fig. IV): the observed signal shape has heavier tails than a Gaussian. Replacing the Gaussian by a Crystal Ball shape [12], a Gaussian core with a power-law low-mass tail,

$$S_{\rm CB}(x) \propto \begin{cases} e^{-x^2/2}, & x > -\beta, \\ \left(\frac{\kappa}{\beta}\right)^{\kappa} e^{-\beta^2/2} \left(\frac{\kappa}{\beta} - \beta - x\right)^{-\kappa}, & x \leq -\beta, \end{cases} \tag{7}$$

with $x = (m - \mu)/\sigma$, β the point where the tail starts (in units of σ) and κ its power, both free, improves the fit to $\chi^2 = 131.0/86$ ($p = 1.3 \times 10^{-3}$, $\beta = 1.71$, $\kappa = 35$) but moves $A_{\rm raw}$ by only −0.0002 (Table I). The asymmetry

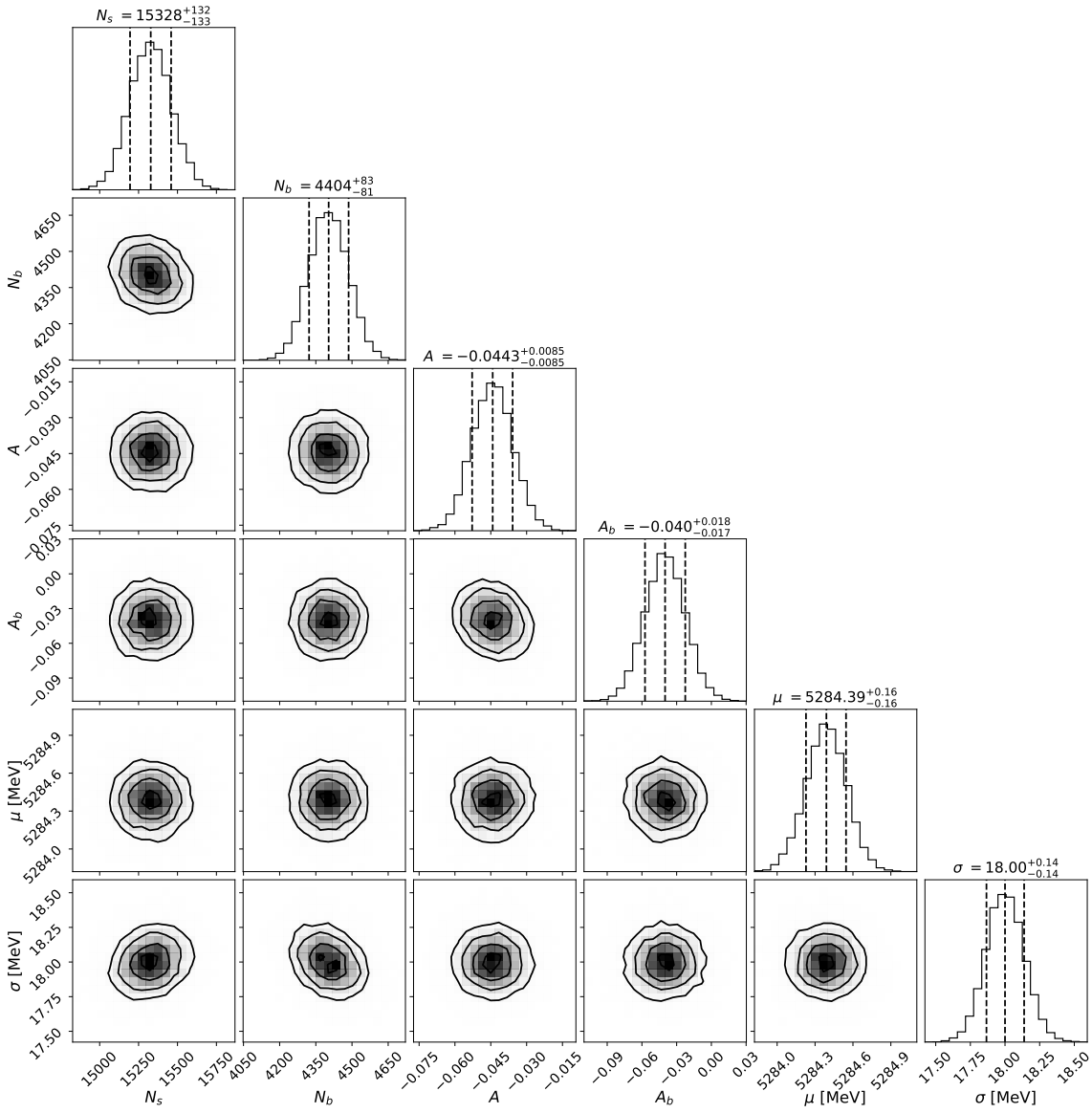


FIG. II. Posterior of the six physics parameters of the nominal fit (the six background-shape parameters are marginalized). Diagonal: marginal posteriors with the 16th, 50th and 84th percentiles (dashed lines and titles). Off-diagonal: 2D marginals, contours at the $0.5, 1, 1.5, 2\sigma$ levels of a 2D Gaussian.

does not depend on the signal shape even though none of the models reaches $\chi^2/\mathrm{ndof} \approx 1$.

The background model is constrained by the data much more strongly. A single exponential per charge is rejected ($\chi^2 = 297.7/92$, $\Delta\chi^2 = 134$ for four fewer parameters), and so it is not used even as a systematic variant (Sec. V). A shape shared between the two charges ($\Delta\chi^2 = 9.9$ for three fewer parameters) and a charge-symmetric background ($\Delta\chi^2 = 5.7$ for one fewer) are acceptable descriptions and shift A_{raw} by -0.0037 and -0.0028: the background treatment is the largest model dependence of the fit. The lower edge of the window is a compromise between two failures. Extending the window to 5050 MeV degrades the fit ($\chi^2 = 217.4/98$), because the double exponential no longer follows the background further below the peak; raising it to 5150 MeV removes most of the region that constrains the steep component, which becomes poorly identified – the chain for its fraction f_+ mixes slowly ($N/\tau = 10$) – while A_{raw} itself is unchanged (-0.0444).

The binned χ^2 uses the posterior medians only. A posterior predictive check [13] accounts for the posterior uncertainty and tests specific features of the data: for 1000 parameter sets θ_j drawn from the posterior, a dataset y_j^{rep} is generated from the model, and a discrepancy $T(y, \theta_j)$ is computed both on the replica and on the data; the posterior predictive p-value is $p_B = P\big(T(y^{\mathrm{rep}}, \theta) \geq T(y, \theta) \mid y\big)$. For the binned χ^2 the replicas give 104 ± 15

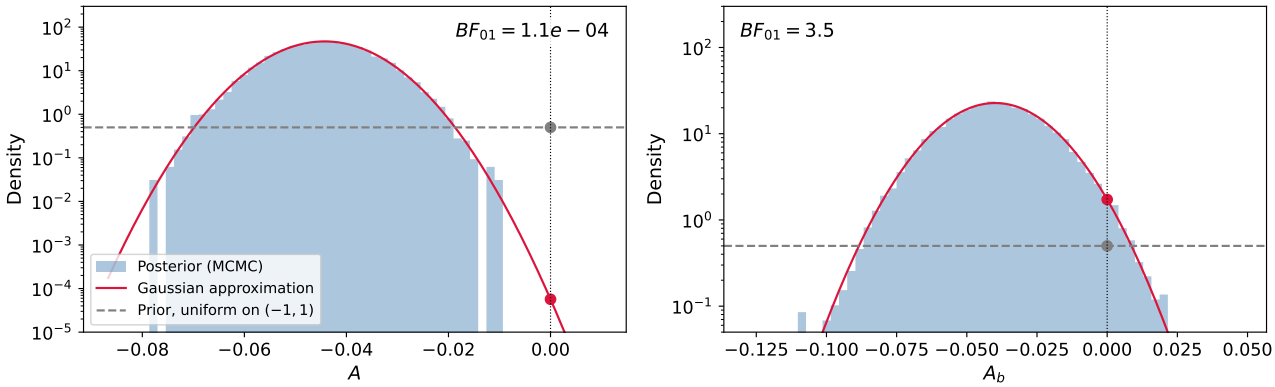


FIG. III. Savage-Dickey ratio for A (left) and A_b (right): marginal posterior (histogram of the chain and Gaussian approximation) and prior density, logarithmic scale. The Bayes factor BF_{01} is the ratio of the two densities at zero (dots). For A the posterior density at zero is 10^{-4} times the prior one; for A_b, 2.3 standard deviations from zero, it is higher than the prior density, and the data favor $A_b = 0$.

and the data 175 (median over θ_j): none of the replicas reaches the observed value ($p_B < 10^{-3}$), with the misfit concentrated in the B^+ sample ($p_B < 10^{-3}$, against 0.03 for B^-). The discrepancies that probe the charge structure of the model are instead reproduced: the counting asymmetry of the whole window ($p_B = 0.996$), of the signal window (0.99) and of the sidebands (0.73) (Fig. V). The model misdescribes the shape of the spectrum, mainly the signal tails, but not the split between the charges that determines $A_{\rm raw}$, consistently with the stability of $A_{\rm raw}$ under changes of the signal model.

Model	$A_{\rm raw}$	χ^2/ndof	p
Nominal	-0.0443	164.1/88	2×10^{-6}
Crystal Ball signal	-0.0445	131.0/86	1×10^{-3}
μ, σ per charge	-0.0443	164.2/86	8×10^{-7}
Shared bkg. shape	-0.0480	174.1/91	4×10^{-7}
Symmetric bkg. ($A_b = 0$)	-0.0471	169.8/89	5×10^{-7}
Single exponential	-0.0480	297.7/92	2×10^{-23}

TABLE I. $A_{\rm raw}$ (posterior median) and goodness of fit of the nominal model (Gaussian signal, double exponential per charge) and of the alternative signal and background models, same data and window.

F. Cross-Checks

The fit was repeated separately on the two magnet polarities, whose left-right detection asymmetries are opposite and partially cancel in the combined sample: $A_{\rm raw}(\text{down}) = -0.0497 \pm 0.0112$ ($n = 11{,}636$) and $A_{\rm raw}(\text{up}) = -0.0378 \pm 0.0129$ ($n = 8095$). They differ by 0.7σ, so there is no indication that the asymmetry is an artifact of one polarity (Fig. VI). A narrower prior, $A \in (-0.3, 0.3)$, leaves the posterior unchanged ($A_{\rm raw} = -0.0443$), as expected for a posterior far from the prior bounds; the prior width matters only for the Bayes factor (Sec. IV D).

The sample contains $B^\pm$ decays through intermediate charm states, $B^\pm \to D^0 K^\pm$, $J/\psi K^\pm$ and $\chi_{c0} K^\pm$ with D^0, J/ψ, $\chi_{c0} \to K^+K^-$, which are visible as peaks in the opposite-sign $m(K^+K^-)$ spectra. They are part of the $B^\pm \to K^\pm K^+ K^-$ final state and are kept in the nominal sample; removing them changes the observable, from the asymmetry of all $B^\pm \to K^\pm K^+ K^-$ decays to that of the charmless ones, so the vetoes are reported as an informative check rather than as a systematic variation. A candidate is vetoed if either opposite-sign pair, $m(H1, H2)$ or $m(H1, H3)$, lies within ± 30 MeV of the D^0 or J/ψ mass or within ± 60 MeV of the χ_{c0} mass (world-average masses; the wider window for the χ_{c0} reflects its natural width). The D^0 veto alone keeps 18,744 candidates and gives $A_{\rm raw} = -0.0496 \pm 0.0088$; the three vetoes together keep 16,367 and give -0.0423 ± 0.0094. The shifts with respect to the nominal fit, -0.0053 and $+0.0020$, compare with expected statistical fluctuations of 0.0023 and 0.0040 for a subsample of the nominal one (Sec. V); the D^0 veto moves $A_{\rm raw}$ by 2.3 times this amount, i.e. the vetoed $D^0 K^\pm$ candidates have a less negative asymmetry than the rest of the sample.

G. Toy-MC Coverage Validation

A credible interval states where the parameter lies given the data and the prior; nothing guarantees that it also has frequentist coverage, i.e. that over repeated experiments it contains the true value with the stated probability. To check this, 200 pseudo-datasets were generated from the fitted model (parametric bootstrap, with the posterior medians as ground truth and Poisson-fluctuated yields for each charge and component; the truncated Gaussian and exponential masses are drawn with the transformation method, i.e. by inverting their

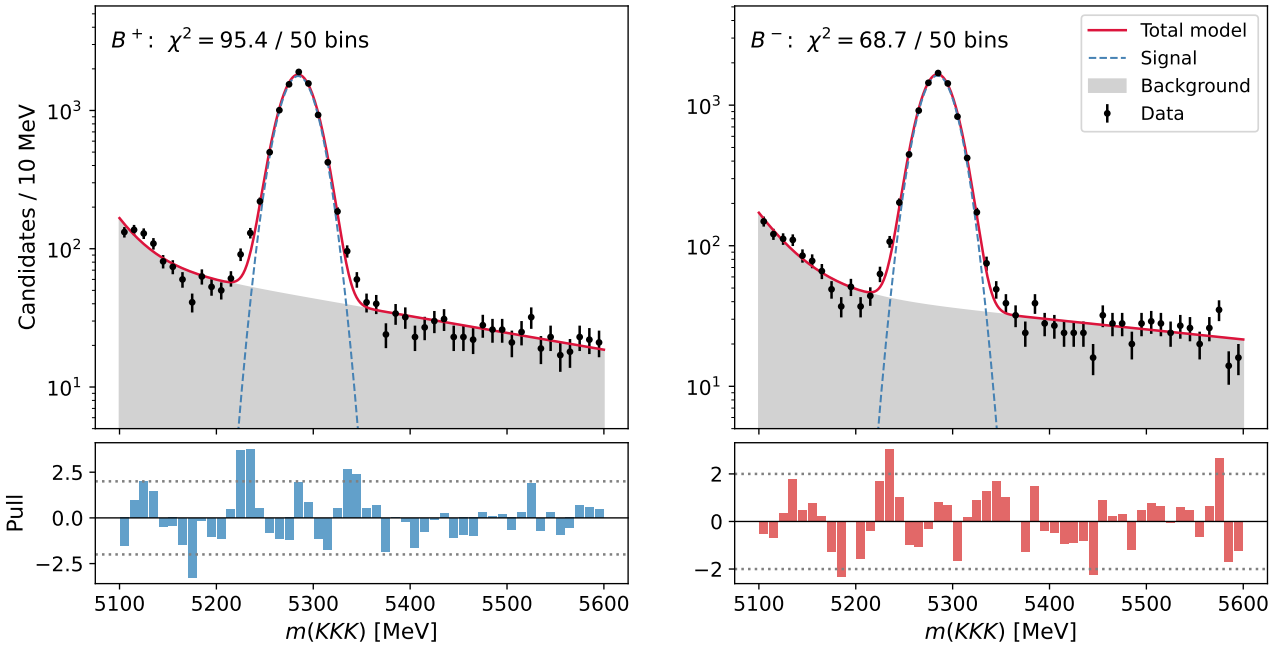


FIG. IV. Mass distributions of B^+ (left) and B^- (right) candidates with the nominal model (posterior medians, logarithmic scale): total, signal and background components. Bottom: pulls, $(\text{obs} - \text{exp})/\sqrt{\text{exp}}$.

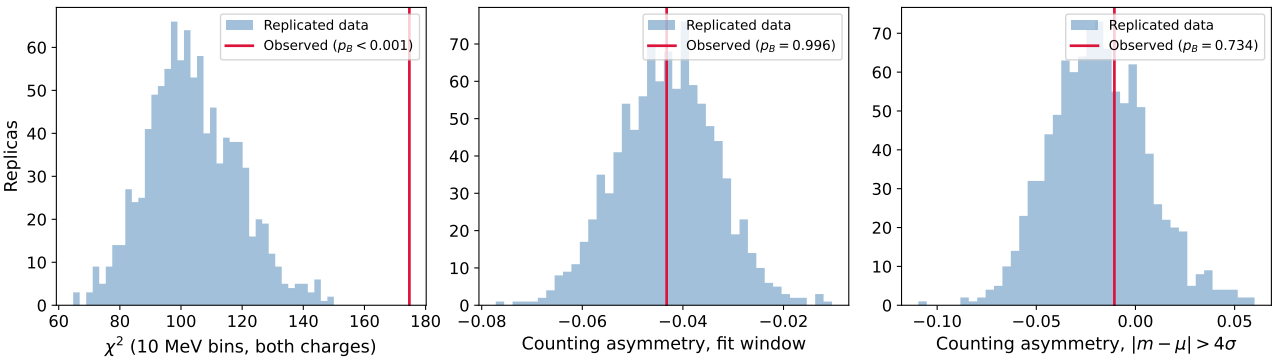


FIG. V. Posterior predictive check: distributions of three discrepancies over 1000 datasets replicated from posterior draws, compared with the observed values. Left: binned χ^2; center and right: counting asymmetry of the fit window and of the sidebands.

cumulative distributions) and each was refit with the nominal procedure and a 12,000-step chain. The fraction of replicas whose interval contains the injected A is 0.650 ± 0.033 for the 68% CI and 0.930 ± 0.015 for the 95% CI (binomial uncertainties), 1.0σ and 1.3σ below nominal: the coverage is consistent with nominal. The estimates themselves are unbiased and their spread matches the reported uncertainty (Fig. VII): their mean differs from the injected value by -0.0002 ± 0.0006, their standard deviation, 0.0088, agrees with the posterior standard deviation of the data fit, 0.0085, and the pulls have mean -0.03 ± 0.07 and standard deviation 1.04.

The toy chains are shorter than the nominal one, and in 124 of the 200 replicas the slowest-mixing parameter, always a background-shape parameter, has $N/\tau < 50$ (median 48, minimum 22). The criterion on the slowest parameter is conservative for the quantity tested here: for A itself the median autocorrelation time is 156 steps, so each chain is at least 45 autocorrelation times long in A and provides $\gtrsim 1400$ effectively independent samples of it. The Monte Carlo error on the percentiles of A is then a few per cent of $\sigma(A)$, negligible against the binomial uncertainty of the coverage, and the replicas with $N/\tau < 50$ do not show a lower coverage than the others. This is a closure test of the inference procedure: since the toys are generated from the same model that is fitted, it does not probe the model mismatch of Sec. IV E, which is instead addressed by the systematic study.

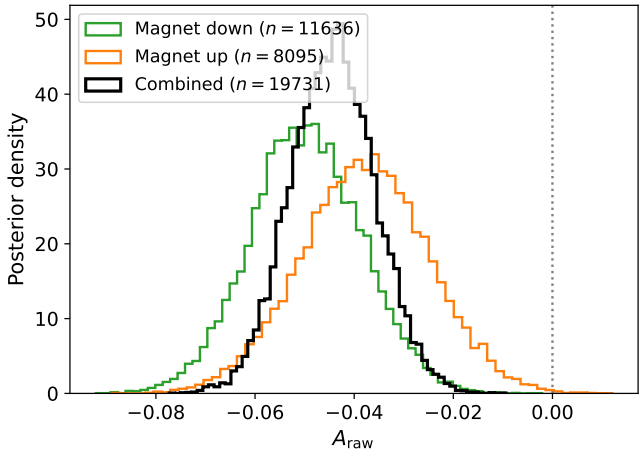


FIG. VI. Posterior of A_{raw} for the magnet-down, magnet-up and combined samples.

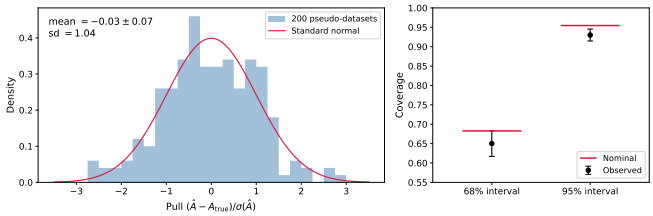


FIG. VII. Toy-MC validation, 200 pseudo-datasets. Left: pulls $(\hat{A} - A_{\mathrm{true}})/\sigma(\hat{A})$, with $\hat{A}$ and $\sigma(\hat{A})$ the posterior median and standard deviation of each replica, compared with a standard normal. Right: fraction of replicas whose 68% and 95% credible intervals contain the injected value, with binomial uncertainties, and the nominal coverage.

H. Local Dalitz-Plot Asymmetry (Fixed Binning)

To test whether the asymmetry is uniform over phase space or concentrated in specific regions, each candidate was placed in the Dalitz plane using the two opposite-sign K^+K^- invariant masses $m^2(H1, H2)$ and $m^2(H1, H3)$ (Sec. II A), sorted into m^2_{lo} and m^2_{hi} to remove the $H2/H3$ labeling ambiguity. The plane $[0, 16] \times [0, 30]$ GeV^2 in $(m^2_{\mathrm{lo}}, m^2_{\mathrm{hi}})$ was divided into an 8×8 grid, fixed before looking at the asymmetries. In each bin with at least 20 candidates (32 of 64), the local asymmetry $A_i = (N_i^- - N_i^+)/N_i$, with binomial uncertainty $\sigma(A_i) = \sqrt{(1 - A_i^2)/N_i}$, was compared with the global counting asymmetry $A_{\mathrm{glob}} = -0.043$ through $S_i = (A_i - A_{\mathrm{glob}})/\sigma(A_i)$; a comparison with zero would instead mostly reflect the global asymmetry itself.

Two of the 32 bins have $|S_i| > 3$, adjacent to each other at $m^2_{\mathrm{lo}} < 4$ GeV^2 and $7.5 < m^2_{\mathrm{hi}} < 11.25$ GeV^2 ($S_i = -3.7$ and -3.0), with A_i more negative than the global value; the bin below the first one ($m^2_{\mathrm{lo}} < 2$, $3.75 < m^2_{\mathrm{hi}} < 7.5$ GeV^2) has $S_i = -2.98$, just under the threshold (Fig. VIII); about 0.09 would be expected if the asymmetry were uniform, with a probability of 3×10^{-3} for two or more. The largest positive deviations, close to +3, lie at high m^2_{hi}. A global test of homogeneity, $\chi^2 = \sum_i S_i^2 = 80.8$ for 31 degrees of freedom ($p = 3 \times 10^{-6}$), confirms that the local asymmetry is not uniform. Restricting the sample to the signal window ($|m - \mu| < 2\sigma$, $n = 15{,}130$, where the fitted model gives a signal purity of ≈96%) gives the same picture – three bins with $|S_i| > 3$, $\chi^2 = 95.6/28$ – so the structure is not produced by the combinatorial background. Nor is it produced by the charm contributions: with the D^0 veto two bins still exceed 3σ ($\chi^2 = 79.2/31$), and with all three vetoes one remains ($\chi^2 = 74.4/31$, $p = 2 \times 10^{-5}$). It does not depend on the binning either: 6×6, 10×10 and 12×12 grids give $\chi^2 = 81.0/19$, $97.1/43$ and $120.0/60$ ($p \leq 7 \times 10^{-6}$).

Two null tests check the procedure itself. Shuffling the charges among the candidates removes any local asymmetry while keeping the occupancy of the bins and the global asymmetry of the data: over 2000 permutations the 8×8 grid gives $\chi^2 = 31.4 \pm 8.1$, as expected for 31 degrees of freedom, and no permutation reaches the observed value (permutation $p < 5 \times 10^{-4}$; $p = 1 \times 10^{-3}$ for the 12×12 grid). The phase-space simulation of the record, without asymmetry by construction, gives $\chi^2 = 40.0/30$ ($p = 0.11$) with the same procedure. The homogeneity test therefore has its nominal behavior, and the non-uniformity is a property of the data. Three caveats apply: the binning is coarse and was not optimized; the asymmetries are computed on all candidates, without the sWeight-based background subtraction that a full analysis would use (Sec. VIII); and, since A_{raw} is not corrected for detection asymmetries, local variations can also be instrumental – the K^+/K^- detection asymmetry depends on the kaon momenta, which are correlated with the position in the Dalitz plane. Section VI E revisits the same question with an adaptive, data-driven partition (K-means).

I. A Minimal Model as Cross-Check

Before the nominal model was fixed, the same analysis was carried out with a minimal six-parameter model: a narrower window, $[5150, 5450]$ MeV, which excludes most of the rising background below the peak, a single exponential background with a shape and a yield shared by the two charges, and the same Gaussian signal. On its 17,839 candidates it gives $A_{\mathrm{raw}} = -0.0497$ (68% CI $[-0.058, -0.041]$) with $\chi^2/\mathrm{ndof} = 127.4/54$, and -0.0457 when the background yields of the two charges are left free. Its toy validation, with 500 pseudo-datasets, gives coverage consistent with nominal (0.664 and 0.962 for the 68% and 95% intervals). **[TODO: check the minimal-model toy numbers against the rerun of Bayesian_Analysis.ipynb (2026-10-07).]** The difference from the nominal result, 0.005, is driven by the background treatment, as in the systematic study of Sec. V,

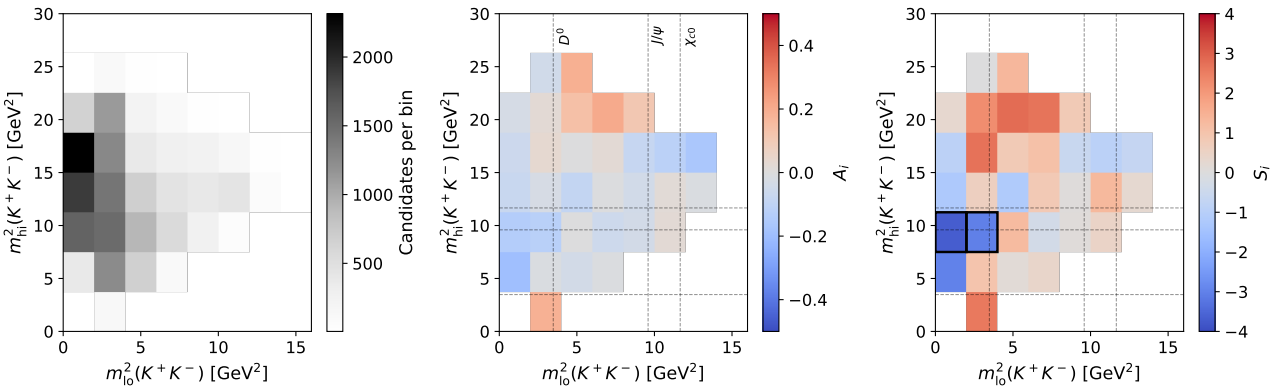


FIG. VIII. Fixed 8×8 Dalitz-plot binning, all candidates in the fit window: number of candidates per bin (left), local asymmetry A_i for bins with ≥ 20 candidates (center), and local significance with respect to the global asymmetry, $(A_i - A_{\rm glob})/\sigma(A_i)$ (right). The two bins with $|S_i| > 3$ are outlined. Dashed lines: the squared masses of the D^0, J/ψ and χ_{c0}, in either opposite-sign pair.

and is smaller than the statistical uncertainty.

V. SYSTEMATIC UNCERTAINTIES

The frequentist and Bayesian fits share one systematic study: the same thirteen variants of the nominal choices, in four groups, and the same rule to combine them. Each variant is fitted by both methods on exactly the same candidates.

- *Window*: lower edge at 5050 or 5150 MeV, upper edge at 5450 or 5700 MeV.
- *Background*: a single exponential per charge; a double exponential with the shape shared between charges; a charge-symmetric background ($A_b = 0$).
- *Signal*: a Crystal Ball shape with free tail parameters, Eq. (7); μ and σ separate for the two charges.
- *Preselection*: one cut at a time loosened or tightened, `ProbK` > 0.4 or > 0.6, `ProbPi` < 0.4 or < 0.6, on all three tracks.

The shift $\Delta = A^{\rm var}_{\rm raw} - A^{\rm nom}_{\rm raw}$ of a variant is not necessarily a systematic effect. When a variant changes the sample (window, preselection), the two samples are nested and part of the shift is a statistical fluctuation, with expected size $\sigma_B = \sqrt{|\sigma^2_{\rm var} - \sigma^2_{\rm nom}|}$, σ being the statistical uncertainty of each fit [14]; such a variant contributes only if $|\Delta| > \sigma_B$. A variant that the data reject, with a χ^2 worse than the nominal one by more than 25 on the same data, is not a plausible alternative and is excluded: this removes the single exponential ($\Delta\chi^2 = 134$, Sec. IV E). The largest remaining $|\Delta|$ of each group is taken as its uncertainty, since the variants of a group are alternative descriptions of the same choice, and the four groups are added in quadrature.

The results are in Table II, and all the Bayesian fits, with their intervals and goodness of fit, in Table V of the Appendix. The two methods give the same shifts to within $\sim$0.0005 and the same group uncertainties, with total systematic uncertainties of 0.0070 (Bayesian) and 0.0072 (frequentist). The final results are

$$\text{Bayesian:}$$
$$A_{\rm raw} = -0.0443 \pm 0.0085\,(\text{stat}) \pm 0.0070\,(\text{syst}),$$
$$\text{frequentist:}$$
$$A_{\rm raw} = -0.0441 \pm 0.0085\,(\text{stat}) \pm 0.0072\,(\text{syst}).$$

The preselection dominates, through the single variant `ProbK` > 0.6 ($+0.0058$, $1.2\,\sigma_B$). To tell a dependence on the PID requirement from a fluctuation of that single value, the frequentist fit was repeated in steps of 0.05 of each cut, from `ProbK` > 0.30 to > 0.85 and from `ProbPi` < 0.15 to < 0.70. On the tight side of the kaon requirement the shifts scatter around zero without a trend ($+0.0009$, $+0.0058$, -0.0017, -0.0112, -0.0054, $+0.0010$, $+0.0022$ for `ProbK` > 0.55–0.85, all within $1.3\,\sigma_B$), and the pion requirement gives a flat scan within $1.3\,\sigma_B$: the `ProbK` > 0.6 value is a statistical fluctuation, and the preselection uncertainty is a conservative estimate. Loosening the kaon requirement, instead, moves $A_{\rm raw}$ monotonically (-0.0019, -0.0032, -0.0067, -0.0111 for `ProbK` > 0.45–0.30, the last at $2.5\,\sigma_B$), as expected if misidentified $B \to K\pi\pi$ and $B \to \pi KK$ decays, with asymmetries of their own and not included in the mass model, enter the sample; this supports the nominal requirement. The combination rule was fixed before this scan and is not changed by it. The background group is the second contribution and is driven by the assumptions on the charge dependence of the background, the window the third.

Each method computes σ_B from its own uncertainties (posterior standard deviation, Hesse error). Since σ_B is the difference of two nearly equal uncertainties, it is sensitive to small differences between them, including the Monte Carlo noise of the posterior standard deviation (1–3%), and a variant close to the threshold can be classified differently by the two methods: `ProbPi` < 0.4 counts for

Group	Variant	n	Δ Bayes	σ_B Bayes	Δ freq.	σ_B freq.
Window	$[5050, 5600]$	21164	-0.0003	0.0009	-0.0004	0.0005
	$[5150, 5600]$	18566	-0.0001	0.0007	-0.0005	0.0021
	$[5100, 5450]$	19004	$+0.0002$	0.0009	-0.0001	0.0003
	$[5100, 5700]$	20191	$\mathbf{-0.0014}$	0.0010	$\mathbf{-0.0014}$	0.0001
Background	single exponential (rejected)	19731	-0.0037	–	-0.0039	–
	shape shared between charges	19731	$\mathbf{-0.0037}$	–	$\mathbf{-0.0040}$	–
	symmetric, $A_b = 0$	19731	-0.0028	–	-0.0031	–
Signal	Crystal Ball	19731	$\mathbf{-0.0002}$	–	$\mathbf{-0.0006}$	–
	μ, σ per charge	19731	-0.0000	–	-0.0001	–
Preselection	`ProbK` > 0.4	26553	-0.0032	0.0038	-0.0032	0.0037
	`ProbK` > 0.6	13981	$\mathbf{+0.0058}$	0.0048	$\mathbf{+0.0058}$	0.0050
	`ProbPi` < 0.4	17984	$+0.0022$	0.0022	$+0.0020$	0.0023
	`ProbPi` < 0.6	20953	-0.0004	0.0020	-0.0006	0.0017
Group uncertainties: window / background / signal / preselection				0.0014/0.0037/0.0002/0.0058		0.0014/0.0040/0.0006/0.0058
Total (quadrature)				0.0070		0.0072

TABLE II. Systematic study common to the Bayesian and frequentist fits: shift of A_{raw} for each variant and, for the variants that change the sample, the expected statistical spread σ_B of the shift. The largest contributing shift of each group is in bold. The single exponential is rejected by the data and excluded. For the window $[5150, 5600]$ the frequentist uncertainty is scaled from the number of events, since the Hesse matrix of that fit is not accurate.

the Bayesian fit ($|\Delta| = 0.00223$, $\sigma_B = 0.00220$) and not for the frequentist one (0.00204 vs 0.00229). This does not affect the result, since the uncertainty of each group is set by its largest shift, the same in both methods.

VI. MACHINE LEARNING MODULE

As a complementary, data-driven approach to the signal/background separation of the mass fits (Secs. III–IV), supervised classifiers were trained on weak labels derived from the mass spectrum, and used to study whether an ML-assisted event selection changes A_{raw} or the mass spectrum, and whether an adaptive partition of the Dalitz plane resolves local structure.

A. Weak Labels and Feature Set

No candidate carries a true signal/background label, so the classifiers are trained with weak labels, following the classification-without-labels (CWoLa) approach [15]: a classifier is trained to separate two *mixed* samples with different signal fractions, here a signal-enriched window around the B peak and the mass sidebands. If, within each class, the feature distributions are the same in the two samples, the optimal classifier between the two mixtures is a monotonic function of the signal-to-background likelihood ratio $p_s(x)/p_b(x)$, which by the Neyman-Pearson lemma is the most powerful test statistic for signal against background: the classifier trained on the mixtures is also the optimal signal/background classifier [15]. Two conditions follow. The background in the sidebands must be representative of the background under the peak; and the features must not be correlated with the B mass. The second condition cannot hold exactly: the reconstructed mass is not an input feature, but the nine momentum components of the three kaons determine it, so a flexible model can partly learn the mass, separate the two mass regions rather than signal from background, and *sculpt* the mass distribution of the candidates that pass a cut on its score. Section VI F tests this directly.

The labels use the nominal Bayesian fit (Sec. IV C, $\mu = 5284.39$, $\sigma = 18.00$ MeV). Candidates with $|m - \mu| < 2\sigma$, $m \in [5248.4, 5320.4]$ MeV, are labeled signal-like (15,130); candidates in $[5150, \mu - 4\sigma] \cup [\mu + 4\sigma, 5600] = [5150, 5212.4] \cup [5356.4, 5600]$ MeV are labeled background-like (1940); the 2–4σ gap is left unlabeled. The region 5100–5150 MeV, inside the fit window, is excluded from the background-like class to satisfy the first condition: there the background rises towards partially reconstructed B decays (Sec. II B), whose kinematics differ from those of the combinatorial background under the peak. The classes are imbalanced ($1940/15{,}130 = 0.128$). Every model is trained with the same balanced class weights, $w_c = N/(2N_c)$, i.e. 4.40 for background-like and 0.56 for signal-like candidates (through `class_weight` for the scikit-learn models and the network, and through sample weights for gradient boosting), so that the two classes contribute equally to the loss.

The feature set consists of the 6 per-track kinematic/PID variables (`PX`, `PY`, `PZ`, `ProbK`, `ProbPi`, `IPChi2`) for each of the 3 final-state tracks (18 features), plus two B-candidate variables not used in the preselection: `B_FlightDistance` and `B_VertexChi2`, standard discriminants against combinatorial background (a genuine B flies further before decaying and has a better-reconstructed vertex than a random track combination). Both separate the weak-label classes (Kolmogorov-Smirnov $p < 10^{-60}$) and are not redundant with the per-

track features (Spearman $|\rho| \leq 0.53$ with each of the 18), giving 20 features. A principal-component analysis of the standardized features needs 15 of 20 components to reach 90% of the variance, so no dimensionality reduction is applied. The labeled sample was split 60/20/20 into training, validation and test sets (10,242/3414/3414 candidates, 388 background-like in the test set), stratified on the label, with the feature scaler fit on the training set only.

B. Model Comparison

Six classifiers were trained: logistic regression, without and with an $L1$ penalty (linear baselines), a decision tree (depth 4), a Random Forest [16] (300 trees of depth 8), gradient boosting [17] (200 stages of depth-3 trees, learning rate 0.05), and a feed-forward neural network (FFNN: two hidden layers of 32 and 16 units with ReLU activation, dropout 0.2, binary cross-entropy, the Adam optimizer [18] with learning rate 10^{-3}, early stopping on the validation AUC). The models are compared through the area under the receiver operating characteristic (ROC) curve (AUC), which equals the probability that a randomly chosen signal-like candidate receives a higher score than a randomly chosen background-like one (0.5 for a random classifier, 1 for a perfect one). Table III gives the 5-fold cross-validated AUC on the training set and the AUC on the untouched test set, with its bootstrap uncertainty. The reference model for the rest of the section was chosen on the cross-validated AUC, so that the test set is not used for any choice: gradient boosting (0.866), essentially tied with the Random Forest (0.863).

Model	CV AUC	Test AUC	Brier
Logistic Regression	0.769 ± 0.016	0.771 ± 0.013	0.197
Logistic Regression (L1)	–	0.771 ± 0.013	0.198
Decision Tree	0.816 ± 0.011	0.824 ± 0.013	0.133
Random Forest	0.863 ± 0.017	0.860 ± 0.012	0.122
Gradient Boosting	$\mathbf{0.866 \pm 0.016}$	0.864 ± 0.012	0.116
FFNN	–	0.857 ± 0.012	0.134

TABLE III. Cross-validated AUC (mean and standard deviation over the folds), test-set AUC (with bootstrap uncertainty) and test-set Brier score of the raw scores. Gradient boosting, best in cross-validation, is the reference model. The FFNN is validated on the validation set instead of by cross-validation.

The three non-linear ensembles and the FFNN improve the AUC by ∼0.09 over the linear models and by ∼0.04 over the single tree (Fig. IX), while their mutual differences (≤ 0.007) are smaller than the test-set uncertainty (0.012). The FFNN training is reproducible (fixed seeds, deterministic operations); its dependence on the random initialization, measured by retraining it with ten seeds, is 0.854 ± 0.005 in test AUC.

The two measures of the relevance of a feature available here – the Random Forest importance (the decrease in Gini impurity $G = 1 - \sum_c p_c^2$, p_c the class fractions in a node, produced by the splits on that feature) and the magnitude of the $L1$-regularized (Lasso [19]) logistic-regression coefficient of the standardized feature – agree only partly (Fig. X; Spearman correlation of the two rankings 0.42, $p = 0.06$). The impact-parameter variables `IPChi2` dominate the Random Forest, while the Lasso coefficients are largest for `B_FlightDistance`, `H3_IPChi2`, `H2_PZ` and `B_VertexChi2`. The difference is expected: the Gini importance reflects the use of a feature in non-linear splits and interactions, and is shared among correlated features, while a linear coefficient measures the effect of a feature with the others held fixed. Both measures rank the two B-candidate variables among the top five (Random Forest 4th and 5th, Lasso 1st and 4th): they summarize in one number the displaced-vertex topology that the per-track variables encode only jointly.

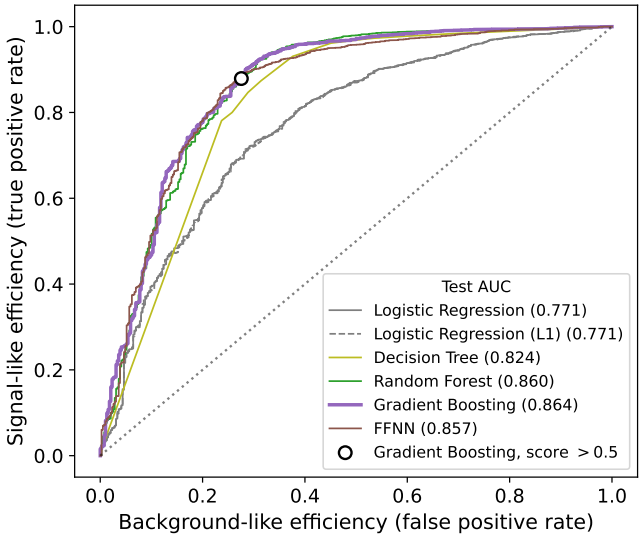


FIG. IX. ROC curves on the test set, with the test AUC of each model in the legend (Table III); the reference model is drawn thicker, and the two logistic regressions overlap. The circle marks the cut on the reference score used in Sec. VI F.

C. Regularization, Bias-Variance, and Calibration

A scan of the regularization strength of the logistic regression (30 log-spaced values of $C = 1/\alpha$, cross-validated) gives the same optimal AUC for the $L1$ and $L2$ penalties (0.7686, at $C_{L1} = 0.12$ and $C_{L2} = 9.2$), and the optimal $L1$ penalty sets no coefficient to zero: the linear model does not overfit, and its limitation is the linear decision boundary, not the variance.

The bias-variance trade-off was studied with gradient boosting, whose complexity grows with the number of boosting stages (Fig. XI). The test AUC rises up to ∼150 stages and then stays at 0.865, while the training AUC keeps rising: the train-test gap grows from 0.018 at 20 stages to 0.084 at 300. The additional stages fit fluc-

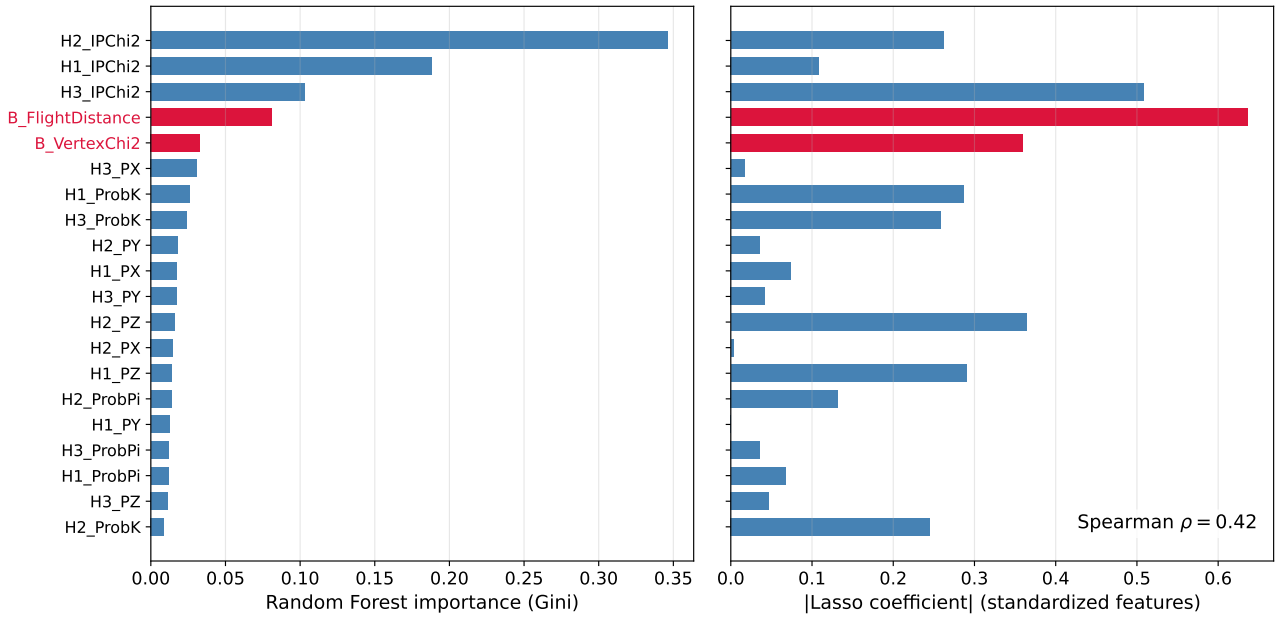


FIG. X. Random Forest feature importance (Gini, left) and magnitude of the Lasso coefficient of the standardized feature (right) for the 20 features, both ordered by Random Forest importance; the two B-candidate variables are highlighted.

tuations of the training sample without improving the ranking of new candidates – overfitting, which the default 200 stages of Table III do not reach in the test AUC. The accuracy at the 0.5 threshold stays below that of always predicting the majority class (0.886): with balanced class weights the classifier is trained to minimize the weighted error, in which a misclassified background-like candidate counts eight times more than a signal-like one, and not the unweighted error rate.

The AUC depends only on the ranking of the scores; whether a score can be read as a probability is measured by the Brier score [20], $\mathrm{BS} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_i (p_i - y_i)^2$, the mean squared difference between predicted probability p_i and label $y_i \in \{0, 1\}$ (lower is better). Class weights change the probabilities a model learns: a classifier trained with weights w_s, w_b on the two classes converges to

$$\tilde{p} = \frac{w_s p}{w_s p + w_b (1 - p)}$$

instead of the true p, i.e. it describes a world in which the classes are re-balanced. With $w_b > w_s$ the raw scores therefore *underestimate* the probability of the signal-like class, which is what the reliability diagram of the Random Forest shows (Fig. XII): at a raw score of 0.25 the observed signal-like fraction is already 0.58. An isotonic recalibration [21], fitted on held-out folds of the unweighted training sample, follows the diagonal and halves the Brier score, from 0.122 to 0.062. Most of the gain undoes the reweighting rather than correcting the model; the ranking, and hence the AUC and any selection based on a score threshold, is unchanged by a monotonic recalibration.

D. Uncertainty Quantification

The uncertainty of a prediction has two components: *aleatoric*, from the intrinsic overlap of the classes in feature space, which more training data cannot reduce, and *epistemic*, from the limited knowledge of the model parameters, which more training data reduces. Three estimators were compared, each giving an ensemble of M predictions $p_m(x)$ for each candidate and quoting their spread, $\sigma(x) = \left[\frac{1}{M}\sum_m (p_m(x) - \bar{p}(x))^2\right]^{1/2}$: the $M = 300$ trees of the Random Forest, each trained on a bootstrap sample; $M = 300$ forward passes of the FFNN with dropout kept active at inference (MC dropout), which approximates sampling from a Bayesian posterior over the network weights [22]; and a deep ensemble [23] of $M = 10$ FFNNs trained from different random initializations. The mean per-candidate uncertainty is 0.178 for the Random Forest, 0.095 for MC dropout (0.099 ± 0.006 over the ten initializations) and 0.050 for the deep ensemble (Fig. XIII), with the same values within 10% for background-like and signal-like candidates.

The three estimators answer different questions, which explains the factor ∼3.5 between them. The deep ensemble only varies the initialization, on the same training data; MC dropout also perturbs the network structure; the trees of the Random Forest differ in their training data (bootstrap) and in the features they use, and each tree, of limited depth, is individually a poor and discrete estimator of p. Their per-candidate values are correlated but not interchangeable (Spearman correlations 0.41–0.57 between pairs). The Random Forest spread contains both components. It is largest for scores around

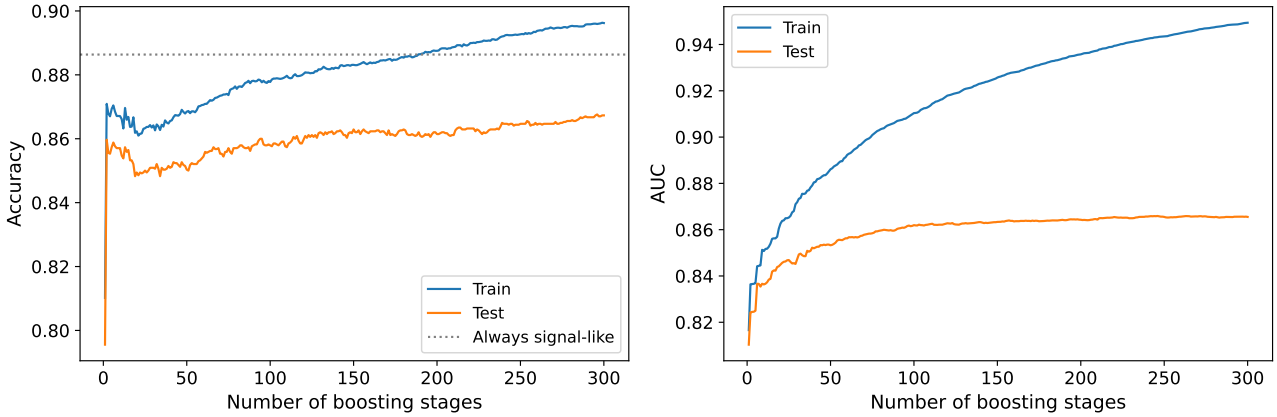


FIG. XI. Gradient boosting: accuracy at the 0.5 threshold (left) and AUC (right) on the training and test sets as a function of the number of boosting stages. The dotted line is the accuracy of always predicting the signal-like class.

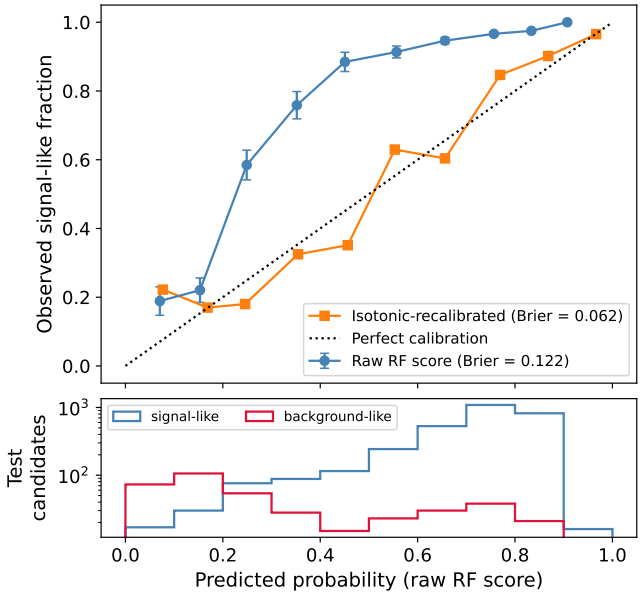


FIG. XII. Reliability diagram of the Random Forest on the test set: observed fraction of signal-like candidates vs. predicted probability, for the raw score (with binomial uncertainties) and for the isotonic-recalibrated one. Bottom: distribution of the raw score for the two weak-label classes; the low-probability bins contain few candidates.

0.5 (Fig. XIII, left), where the classes overlap and the trees disagree most – an aleatoric contribution; and it decreases with the size of the training set, from 0.220 with a quarter of it to 0.204 with half and 0.179 with the full set, while the test AUC stays at 0.860–0.862 – the epistemic contribution, which more data reduces.

E. K-means on the Dalitz Plot

As an adaptive alternative to the fixed Dalitz-plot binning of Sec. IV H, the candidates of the fit window were partitioned with K-means [24] on the two standardized Dalitz variables $(m^2_{\rm lo}, m^2_{\rm hi})$. K-means partitions the points x_i into K clusters C_k minimizing the within-cluster sum of squares (inertia) $W = \sum_k \sum_{i\in C_k} \|x_i - \bar{x}_k\|^2$, with $\bar{x}_k$ the cluster centroids; K has to be fixed in advance. The quality of a partition is measured by the silhouette [25]: for each point, $s_i = (b_i - a_i)/\max(a_i, b_i)$ compares its mean distance a_i to the other points of its cluster with the mean distance b_i to the points of the nearest other cluster, and the average over all points ($-1 \le s \le 1$, higher is better) measures how well separated the clusters are. $K = 8$ was fixed in advance, as a compromise between resolution and the number of candidates per cluster (at least 1233), and $K = 3$, the silhouette optimum over $K = 2$–12 (0.46, against 0.41 for $K = 8$, a local maximum), was added. Both partitions are stable: repeating the clustering with a different random initialization gives an adjusted Rand index [26] above 0.998.

The asymmetry of each cluster was compared with the global one as in Sec. IV H, $S_k = (A_k - A_{\rm glob})/\sigma(A_k)$. For $K = 8$ (Fig. XIV), two clusters deviate by more than 3σ (probability 2×10^{-4} for two or more if the asymmetry were uniform), and the homogeneity test gives $\chi^2 = 46.4/7$ ($p = 7 \times 10^{-8}$). The most significant one lies at low $m^2_{\rm lo}$ (1–2.5 GeV^2) and intermediate $m^2_{\rm hi}$, with $A_k = -0.127 \pm 0.017$ ($n = 3601$, $S_k = -5.1$); two clusters at high $m^2_{\rm hi}$ have positive asymmetries, $A_k = +0.020 \pm 0.020$ ($S_k = +3.2$) and $+0.040 \pm 0.028$ ($+2.9$). In the signal window ($|m - \mu| < 2\sigma$) the same pattern is sharper – three clusters beyond 3σ, with $S_k = -5.6$, $+4.4$ and $+3.0$, and $\chi^2 = 62.3/7$ – so it is not produced by the background. The coarser $K = 3$ partition gives $\chi^2 = 15.2/2$ ($p = 5\times10^{-4}$). The adaptive partition therefore confirms the picture of the fixed binning, a negative

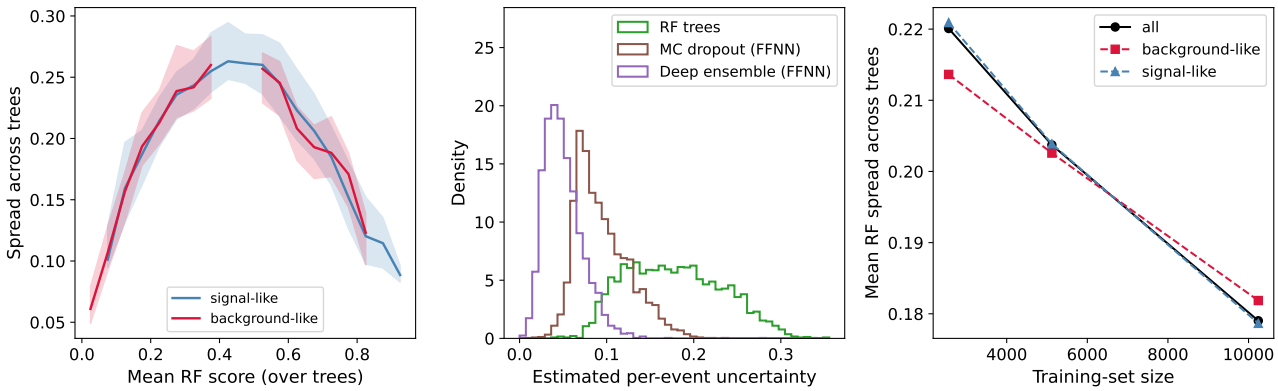


FIG. XIII. Left: spread across the Random Forest trees vs. mean tree score, median and 16–84% band of the test candidates of each weak-label class. Center: distributions of the per-candidate uncertainty from the Random Forest trees, MC dropout and the deep ensemble. Right: mean Random Forest spread vs. training-set size, for all, background-like and signal-like test candidates.

local asymmetry at low $m^2_{\rm lo}$ and positive ones at high $m^2_{\rm hi}$, with the same caveats (no background subtraction, no correction for detection asymmetries).

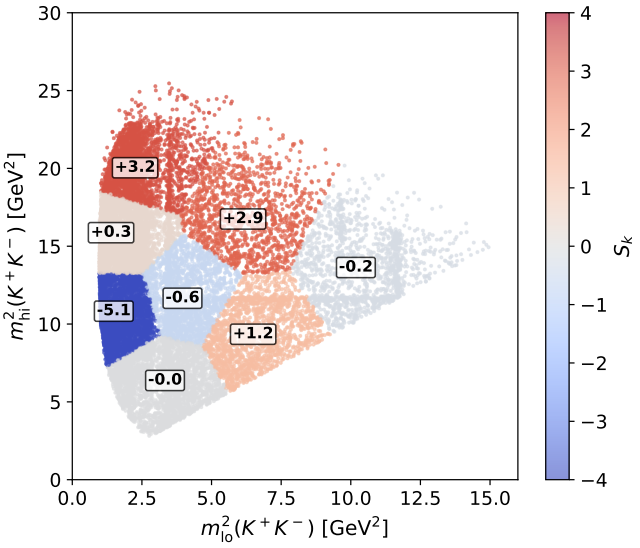


FIG. XIV. K-means partition ($K = 8$) of the Dalitz plane, all candidates of the fit window, same axes as Fig. VIII. Color and labels: local significance of each cluster with respect to the global asymmetry, $S_k = (A_k - A_{\rm glob})/\sigma(A_k)$, on the same scale as the right panel of Fig. VIII.

F. Stability of $A_{\rm raw}$ under ML Selection

The reference (gradient-boosting) score was applied to all candidates of the fit window (on the test set, a cut at 0.5 keeps 88% of the signal-like and 28% of the background-like candidates, Fig. IX), not only to the labeled ones used in training, and the counting asymmetry was recomputed after cuts on the score from 0.1 to 0.9 (Fig. XV). Since every selected sample is contained in the full one, the expected statistical spread of the difference is $\sqrt{\sigma^2_{\rm sub} - \sigma^2_{\rm full}}$, not the uncertainty of either estimate. Over all thresholds, which keep from 18,443 to 2621 candidates, the shift with respect to the full window ($A_{\rm count} = -0.0432$) stays within 1.4 times this spread: the selection does not introduce a detectable bias in the counting asymmetry. Split by magnet polarity at a cut of 0.5, the counting asymmetries are -0.060 ± 0.010 (down) and -0.024 ± 0.012 (up), 2.2σ apart; the frequentist fit of the same samples, which separates the background, gives -0.054 ± 0.011 and -0.032 ± 0.013, 1.3σ apart (against 0.7σ for the full sample, Sec. IV F), so most of the larger difference of the counting estimates comes from the background.

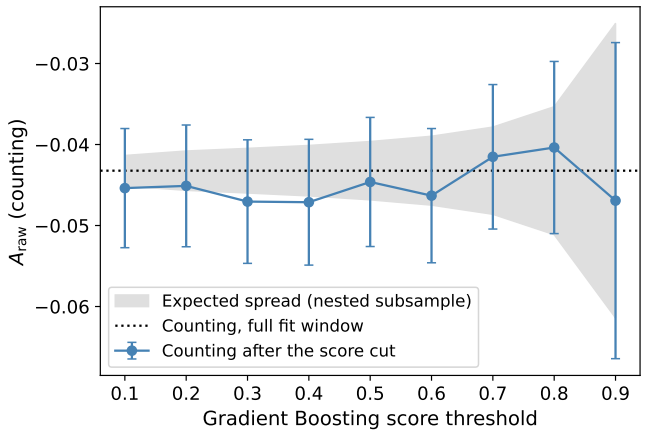


FIG. XV. Counting asymmetry after a cut on the gradient-boosting score, vs. threshold, with its binomial uncertainty. Dotted line: counting asymmetry of the full fit window; band: expected statistical spread of a nested subsample around it, $\pm\sqrt{\sigma^2_{\rm sub} - \sigma^2_{\rm full}}$.

Counting cannot reveal whether the selection deforms

the mass spectrum. To test this, the selected sample (score > 0.5, 15,709 candidates) was refitted with the nominal mass model by both inference methods of this work, the Bayesian fit of Sec. IV and the frequentist maximum-likelihood fit of Sec. III, and the three estimates were compared with those of the full sample (Table IV, Fig. XVI). The asymmetry is stable: all three shifts are within their expected nested-sample spread, and the significance of $A \neq 0$ from the profile likelihood (Wilks' theorem [7]) is 5.2σ in both samples. The selection keeps 92% of the fitted signal and 36% of the background ($N_s = 14{,}121$, $N_b = 1590$), but this does not improve the precision on A_{raw} (0.0087 against 0.0085): the background under the peak is already small (≈4% in the signal window) and the fit separates it from the signal anyway. The mass spectrum, instead, changes. The goodness of fit of the nominal model degrades from $\chi^2 = 164/88$ to 253/88 in the Bayesian fit and from 442/388 to 557/388 in the frequentist one (with a different binning), and the background shape changes: the slope of the slow exponential grows from 0.0028 to 0.0071 MeV^{-1} (B^+) and from 0.0016 to 0.0057 MeV^{-1} (B^-), and the fraction of the steep one from 0.11 to 0.28 and from 0.21 to 0.50. Two mechanisms can produce this: the classifier could reconstruct the mass from the kaon momenta and sculpt the background (Sec. VI A), or the selection could change the composition of the background. The first is excluded: the same classifier trained without the nine momentum components (test AUC 0.860) gives the same degradation ($\chi^2 = 533/388$). The efficiency of the cut as a function of the mass shows the second (Fig. XVII): it is 0.89–0.90 at the peak, ≈ 0.70 below 5150 MeV and 0.06–0.13 above 5375 MeV. The classifier does what it is trained for – it removes the combinatorial background and keeps genuine B decays, including the partially reconstructed ones and the other non-combinatorial components that the weak labels cannot separate from the signal. In the selected sample these components weigh relatively more, and the nominal model, which has no dedicated component for them, describes it worse, mostly under the peak (the χ^2 of the $\pm 4\sigma$ region grows from 75 to 134 for 30 bins) and below it. A Crystal Ball signal gives the same degradation (407 → 522 for 386 degrees of freedom), so it is not due to the signal tails. A_{raw} is unaffected because it is determined by the peak and the background shape is free in the fit, but a measurement that relied on the background shape, or on a background model taken from the sidebands of the full sample, would be biased by the selection.

G. Hyperparameter Optimization

The hyperparameters of the Random Forest (120 configurations), gradient boosting (100) and the FFNN (168: seven architectures, four dropout rates, six learning rates) were optimized by repeated cross-validation on the training set (Tables VI–VII). The best configurations improve

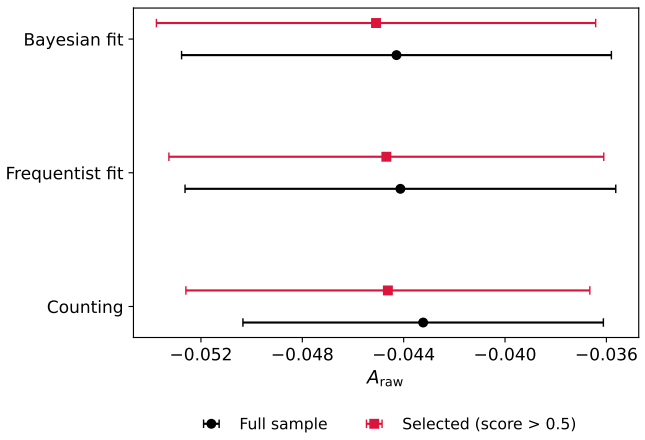


FIG. XVI. A_{raw} from the Bayesian fit, the frequentist fit and counting, for the full sample and the ML-selected one (Table IV).

the test AUC over the defaults of Table III by 0.005 (Random Forest), 0.001 (gradient boosting) and 0.004 (FFNN), all well below the test-set uncertainty (0.012) and, for the FFNN, comparable with its spread over initializations (0.005). For the two tree ensembles the best cross-validated AUC is higher than the test AUC of the same configuration (0.871 vs 0.866 and 0.868 vs 0.865), as expected when the maximum is taken over many noisy cross-validation estimates (the "winner's curse"): the selection favors configurations with a favorable fluctuation, and the cross-validated score of the selected configuration is an optimistic estimate of its performance. The searches show that the defaults are already close to optimal for this problem, so the defaults are used throughout.

VII. COMPARISON AND DISCUSSION

[TODO: Shared, written last once §III exists – the one section that genuinely can't be finished without Marco. Headline comparison table: A_{raw} (counting, frequentist, Bayesian, ML-assisted) with uncertainties, side by side. Comparison with the published A_{CP}(KKK) value from Ref. [1] and discussion of why $A_{\text{raw}} \neq A_{CP}$. Local Dalitz-plot asymmetry: fixed binning vs K-means, and whether the frequentist local significance study (if Marco does one) agrees.]

VIII. LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE WORK

Several modeling choices and known weaknesses limit how far the results of Secs. IV–VI can be pushed, and are collected here rather than scattered through the results sections.

On the mass fits (Secs. IV–V): no tested signal model

Method	Full sample	Score > 0.5	Shift (expected)
Bayesian fit	-0.0443 ± 0.0085	-0.0451 ± 0.0087	$-0.0008\,(0.0018)$
Frequentist fit	-0.0441 ± 0.0085	-0.0447 ± 0.0086	$-0.0006\,(0.0012)$
Counting	-0.0432 ± 0.0071	-0.0446 ± 0.0080	$-0.0014\,(0.0036)$

TABLE IV. A_{raw} on the full fit window (19,731 candidates) and after the cut on the gradient-boosting score (15,709), by the three methods. The expected shift is the statistical spread of a nested subsample, $\sqrt{\sigma^2_{\text{sub}} - \sigma^2_{\text{full}}}$. Counting includes the background.

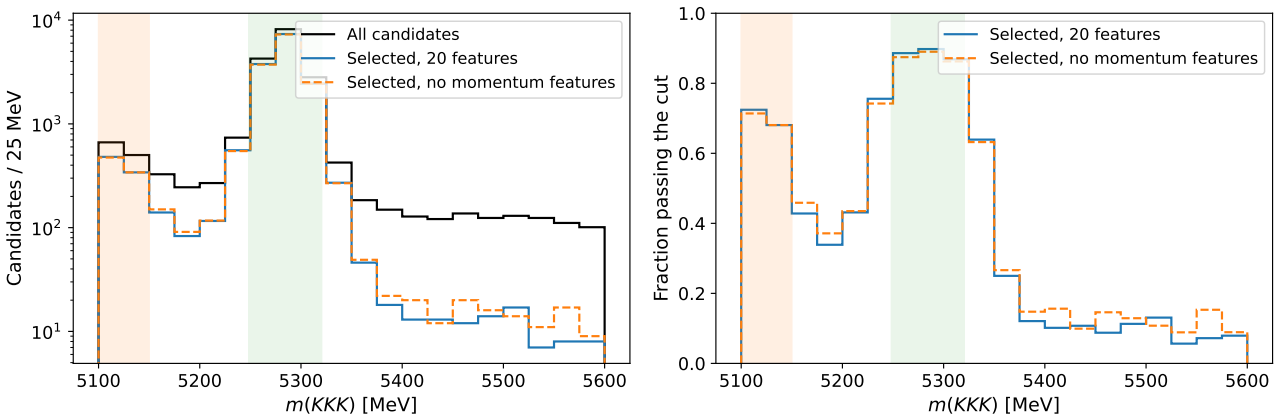


FIG. XVII. Left: mass spectrum of all candidates and of those with gradient-boosting score > 0.5, for the 20-feature classifier and for one trained without the kaon momentum components (25 MeV bins). Right: fraction of candidates passing the cut. Shaded: the region below 5150 MeV excluded from the background-like labels, and the signal-like window.

reaches $\chi^2/\text{ndof} \approx 1$ (the best, a Crystal Ball, gives 131.0/86, Sec. IV E), although A_{raw} does not depend on the signal shape; the systematic uncertainty, 0.007, is almost as large as the statistical one; it is dominated by a PID variant that a finer scan identifies as a statistical fluctuation (Sec. V), so it is conservative, but the combination rule cannot separate the two; the Savage-Dickey Bayes factor of Sec. IV D relies on a Gaussian approximation of the posterior far in its tail and depends on the prior width, though the conclusion (decisive evidence against $A = 0$) is robust; the toy-MC coverage check of Sec. IV G is a closure test and cannot detect model misspecification; and the local Dalitz asymmetries (Secs. IV H and VI E) use a coarse partition, a mass-window cut rather than a proper background subtraction, and no correction for momentum-dependent detection asymmetries.

On the machine-learning side (Sec. VI): the weak labels are imbalanced (1940 background-like vs. 15,130 signal-like candidates, Sec. VI A), and the test set contains only 388 background-like candidates, so differences in test AUC below $\sim$0.01 cannot be resolved; the three uncertainty estimators differ by a factor $\sim$3.5 in scale and measure different sources of variability (Sec. VI D); and the score-based selection changes the composition of the background, keeping the partially reconstructed and other non-combinatorial B decays that the nominal model does not describe (Sec. VI F); removing the momentum features does not help, since the weak labels cannot separate these decays from the signal.

More generally, no detector-level systematic correction (selection efficiency, production asymmetry) is applied anywhere in this work, so A_{raw} as reported throughout is explicitly *not* a measurement of A_{CP} (Sec. VII). The published analysis corrects for $A_P + A_D$ with $B^\pm \to J/\psi K^\pm$, $J/\psi \to \mu^+\mu^-$ [1], which is not part of this record; the $J/\psi \to K^+K^-$ decays inside our sample cannot replace it, since this mode is rare and the 568 candidates under the B peak in the J/ψ band are dominated by charmless decays ($A_{\text{count}} = -0.165 \pm 0.041$, a local Dalitz-plot asymmetry rather than a control measurement).

The most natural next steps, in rough priority order, are: correcting A_{raw} for the production and detection asymmetries with a control channel such as $B^\pm \to J/\psi K^\pm$, $J/\psi \to \mu^+\mu^-$; replacing the fixed-cut local Dalitz asymmetries (both binned, Sec. IV H, and K-means, Sec. VI E) with a proper sWeight-based background subtraction; and an explicit model of the partially reconstructed and other non-combinatorial B backgrounds, which would also make an ML-selected sample usable for a fit.

IX. CONCLUSIONS

[TODO: Shared. Short – synthesize ONE key message per method (does not need to restate every number from the Results sections), state

what was learned methodologically (e.g. "a minimal Gaussian+exponential model is insufficient, a Crystal Ball with floated shape parameters improves the fit without moving $A_{\rm raw}$"), not just what was measured.]

X. AUTHOR CONTRIBUTIONS

Marco Belotti led the frequentist analysis (Sec. III): mass model, likelihood fits, and profile-likelihood confidence interval. Giacomo Moretti led the Bayesian analysis (Sec. IV): model definition, MCMC sampling, convergence diagnostics, Bayes factor, and the associated systematic/goodness-of-fit studies. The common nominal model, the systematic study (Sec. V), the machine learning analysis and the comparison of the three methods on the ML-selected sample (Sec. VI), the toy-MC validation, the Dalitz-plot analyses, and the final cross-method comparison (Sec. VII) were carried out jointly. Both authors contributed to the manuscript.

XI. CODE AND DATA AVAILABILITY

All code is written in Python $\geq$3.12, with `scikit-learn` [27] for the classical machine-learning models and `TensorFlow/Keras` [28] for the neural networks. Key package versions: `uproot 5.7`, `iminuit 2.32` **[TODO: Marco confirm]**, `emcee 3.1.6`, `corner 2.3.0`, `scikit-learn 1.9`, `tensorflow 2.21.0`, `keras 3.15.1`, `scipy 1.18`, `numpy 2.4`, `pandas 3.0`.

The dataset is the CERN Open Data record 4900 ("Matter Antimatter Differences – B meson decays to three hadrons"). The analysis code is available in the accompanying repository, in `Code_general/Frequentist/` (frequentist fits and the common systematic study), `Code_general/Bayesian/` (nominal model, its checks, and the minimal model), and `Code_general/Machine_Learning/`; the figures of this paper are produced from the saved results of those analyses by the scripts in `Report/figures/` (`regen_mass_spectrum.py`, `regen_figures_nominal.py`, `regen_figures_ml_nominal.py`).

Appendix A: Full results tables

[TODO: Shared. Still needed: frequentist fit results alongside the Bayesian rows below, for a direct side-by-side comparison.]

[1] R. Aaij *et al.* (LHCb), Direct CP violation in charmless three-body decays of $B^{\pm}$ mesons, Phys. Rev. D **108**, 012008 (2023), arXiv:2206.07622 [hep-ex].
[2] L. Falcão, CP violation measurements in three-body charmless B decays, on behalf of the LHCb Collaboration, 12th Workshop on the CKM Unitarity Triangle (2024), arXiv:2403.19921 [hep-ex].
[3] LHCb Collaboration, Matter Antimatter Differences – B meson decays to three hadrons (2017), record 4900.
[4] LHCb Collaboration, Matter Antimatter Differences – Project Notebook (2017), record 4902.
[5] H. Dembinski, P. Ongmongkolkul, *et al.*, scikit-hep/iminuit, Zenodo (2020).
[6] F. James and M. Roos, Minuit – a system for function minimization and analysis of the parameter errors and correlations, Computer Physics Communications **10**, 343 (1975).
[7] S. S. Wilks, The large-sample distribution of the likelihood ratio for testing composite hypotheses, Annals of Mathematical Statistics **9**, 60 (1938).
[8] J. Goodman and J. Weare, Ensemble samplers with affine invariance, Commun. Appl. Math. Comput. Sci. **5**, 65 (2010).
[9] D. Foreman-Mackey, D. W. Hogg, D. Lang, and J. Goodman, emcee: The MCMC Hammer, Publ. Astron. Soc. Pac. **125**, 306 (2013), arXiv:1202.3665.
[10] J. M. Dickey, The weighted likelihood ratio, linear hypotheses on normal location parameters, Ann. Math. Statist. **42**, 204 (1971).
[11] H. Jeffreys, *Theory of Probability*, 3rd ed. (Oxford University Press, Oxford, 1961).
[12] T. Skwarnicki, *A study of the radiative cascade transitions between the Υ' and Υ resonances*, Ph.D. thesis, Institute of Nuclear Physics, Krakow (1986), dESY-F31-86-02.
[13] A. Gelman, X.-L. Meng, and H. Stern, Posterior predictive assessment of model fitness via realized discrepancies, Statistica Sinica **6**, 733 (1996).
[14] R. Barlow, Systematic errors: facts and fictions, in *Conference on Advanced Statistical Techniques in Particle Physics* (Durham, 2002) arXiv:hep-ex/0207026.
[15] E. M. Metodiev, B. Nachman, and J. Thaler, Classification without labels: Learning from mixed samples in high energy physics, JHEP **10**, 174, arXiv:1708.02949.
[16] L. Breiman, Random forests, Machine Learning **45**, 5 (2001).
[17] J. H. Friedman, Greedy function approximation: a gradient boosting machine, Annals of Statistics **29**, 1189 (2001).
[18] D. P. Kingma and J. Ba, Adam: A method for stochastic optimization, in *3rd International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)* (2015) arXiv:1412.6980.
[19] R. Tibshirani, Regression shrinkage and selection via the lasso, Journal of the Royal Statistical Society B **58**, 267 (1996).
[20] G. W. Brier, Verification of forecasts expressed in terms of probability, Mon. Weather Rev. **78**, 1 (1950).
[21] B. Zadrozny and C. Elkan, Transforming classifier scores into accurate multiclass probability estimates, in *Proceedings of the 8th ACM SIGKDD International Conference*

Fit	n	A_{raw} (median)	68% CI	χ^2/ndof
Nominal	19731	-0.0443	$[-0.0528, -0.0358]$	164.1/88
Systematic variants (Sec. V)				
Window $[5050, 5600]$	21164	-0.0446	$[-0.0531, -0.0362]$	217.4/98
Window $[5150, 5600]$	18566	-0.0444	$[-0.0528, -0.0359]$	141.5/78
Window $[5100, 5450]$	19004	-0.0440	$[-0.0524, -0.0357]$	136.9/58
Window $[5100, 5700]$	20191	-0.0456	$[-0.0540, -0.0373]$	200.2/108
Single exponential	19731	-0.0480	$[-0.0564, -0.0395]$	297.7/92
Background shape shared	19731	-0.0480	$[-0.0564, -0.0397]$	174.1/91
Symmetric background	19731	-0.0471	$[-0.0552, -0.0388]$	169.8/89
Crystal Ball signal	19731	-0.0445	$[-0.0529, -0.0363]$	131.0/86
μ, σ per charge	19731	-0.0443	$[-0.0527, -0.0356]$	164.2/86
`ProbK` > 0.4	26553	-0.0474	$[-0.0550, -0.0399]$	175.6/88
`ProbK` > 0.6	13981	-0.0385	$[-0.0482, -0.0289]$	145.0/88
`ProbPi` < 0.4	17984	-0.0421	$[-0.0506, -0.0333]$	150.1/88
`ProbPi` < 0.6	20953	-0.0446	$[-0.0529, -0.0366]$	159.0/88
Cross-checks (Secs. IV B, IV F)				
Dispersed start, run 1	19731	-0.0446	$[-0.0529, -0.0360]$	164.1/88
Dispersed start, run 2	19731	-0.0442	$[-0.0528, -0.0356]$	164.1/88
Magnet down	11636	-0.0497	$[-0.0607, -0.0386]$	153.1/88
Magnet up	8095	-0.0378	$[-0.0507, -0.0251]$	150.3/88
Narrow prior, $A \in (-0.3, 0.3)$	19731	-0.0443	$[-0.0528, -0.0358]$	164.1/88
D^0 veto	18744	-0.0496	$[-0.0584, -0.0409]$	159.1/88
D^0, J/ψ, χ_{c0} vetoes	16367	-0.0423	$[-0.0516, -0.0329]$	140.1/88

TABLE V. All Bayesian fits of the nominal model and of its variants: number of candidates, posterior median and 68% credible interval of A_{raw}, and binned goodness of fit (10 MeV bins). Every fit uses 32 walkers and 25,000 steps.

Model	Grid	Best configuration	CV AUC / Test AUC (default)
Random Forest	`n_estimators` 200–1200, `max_depth` 6–12 or none, `min_samples_leaf` 5–40	400, 12, 5	0.8706 / 0.8656 (0.8604)
Gradient Boosting	`n_estimators` 100–500, `max_depth` 1–5, `learning_rate` 0.01–0.1	300, 2, 0.1	0.8684 / 0.8650 (0.8643)

TABLE VI. Hyperparameter search for the tree ensembles (120 and 100 configurations, 5-fold cross-validation repeated 10 times, balanced class weights). The test AUC of the best configuration is compared with that of the default of Table III (in parentheses); the bootstrap uncertainty of each test AUC is 0.012.

on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining (2002) pp. 694–699.

[22] Y. Gal and Z. Ghahramani, Dropout as a Bayesian Approximation: Representing Model Uncertainty in Deep Learning, in *Proceedings of the 33rd International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML)* (2016) arXiv:1506.02142.

[23] B. Lakshminarayanan, A. Pritzel, and C. Blundell, Simple and scalable predictive uncertainty estimation using deep ensembles, in *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems 30* (2017) arXiv:1612.01474.

[24] S. P. Lloyd, Least squares quantization in PCM, IEEE Transactions on Information Theory **28**, 129 (1982).

[25] P. J. Rousseeuw, Silhouettes: A graphical aid to the interpretation and validation of cluster analysis, J. Comput. Appl. Math. **20**, 53 (1987).

[26] L. Hubert and P. Arabie, Comparing partitions, Journal of Classification **2**, 193 (1985).

[27] F. Pedregosa *et al.*, Scikit-learn: Machine learning in Python, Journal of Machine Learning Research **12**, 2825 (2011).

[28] M. Abadi *et al.*, TensorFlow: Large-scale machine learning on heterogeneous distributed systems (2016), arXiv:1603.04467.

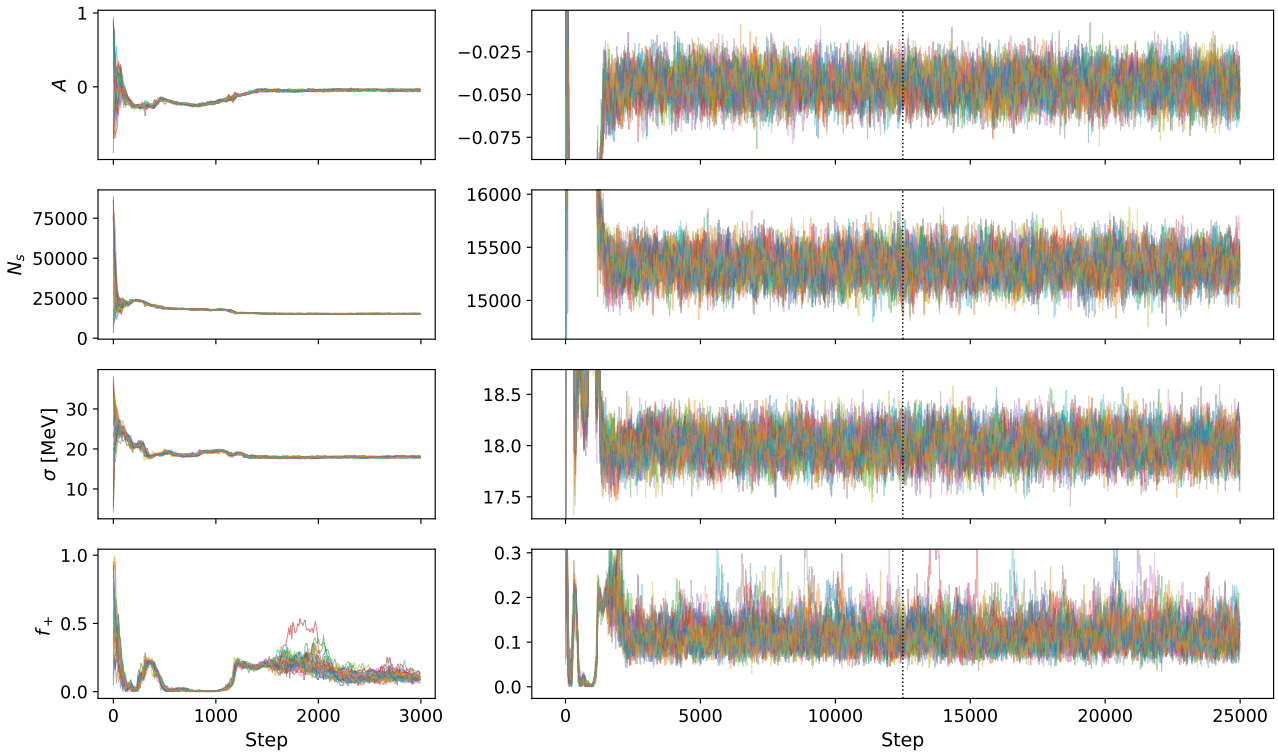


FIG. XVIII. Trace plot of the nominal fit with the 32 walkers initialized uniformly over the prior box (one line per walker, every 10th step), for A, N_s, σ and the steep-background fraction f_+. Left: first 3000 steps, full range; right: whole chain, zoomed on the posterior. The first half of the chain (dotted line) is discarded as burn-in.

Architecture	Layers	Dropout	Learning rate	CV AUC
`deep_3layer` (best)	[64, 32, 16]	0.2	0.003	0.8585 ± 0.0174
`wide_2layer`	[64, 32]	0.3	0.003	0.8582 ± 0.0175
`deep_3layer`	[64, 32, 16]	0.3	0.003	0.8580 ± 0.0187
`wide_2layer`	[64, 32]	0.3	0.005	0.8579 ± 0.0184
`wide_2layer`	[64, 32]	0.4	0.005	0.8579 ± 0.0187

TABLE VII. Top five of the 168 FFNN configurations (7 architectures from one hidden layer of 8 units to five layers $[128, 64, 32, 16, 8]$, dropout 0.1–0.4, learning rates 0.0002–0.005; 5-fold cross-validation repeated twice). The five are within 0.0007 of each other, far below the fold-to-fold spread: the optimum is a plateau. The best configuration has test AUC 0.8606, against 0.8568 for the default architecture (± 0.005 over initializations).